Broken things

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/42156096.

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Teen And Up Audiences

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No Archive Warnings Apply

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Catra (She-Ra), Adora (She-Ra), The other one's are there like... for a second?

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by Wooden_doll

Summary

One day, Catra found a collar in her room.

Notes

I've learned how to use italics on html now.
I'm *proud* of myself.

See the end of the work for more notes

One day, Catra found a collar in her room.

Or…well, Adora's room, but was it technically hers too? It was where she slept and spent most of her time, so was it hers too? Their room? It didn't matter —she shook her head, clearing her thoughts— because there was a collar there, and she didn't know where it had come from or why it was there, and thinking about what it could meant *hurt*.

For most of the morning, she ignored it. Went downstairs and had breakfast, shared laughs with Glimmer and Bow and kisses with Adora, chatted with Scorpia and Perfuma – who extended, again, an invitation to meditate – and attended a meeting where everyone basically sat down, crossed their arms and shared a stunned silence, a "So, what do we do now?" silence, so Catra took pity on them and gave them some ideas.

By the end of three hours, her throat was sore from talking, and a very impressed—if a little sulky—Glimmer gave her the lead on the logistics of the rebuilding plans, because apparently she was as good at fixing things as she was at tearing them down. Part of her thought she should be offended by this, but a much larger part was flattered by the involuntary compliment.

Yes, she was.

It would have been a perfect day, but there was that collar.

Catra couldn't help but think about it, and the more she tried to stop, the worse it got. Two days later, she was frustrated and irritable, the collar going back and forth in her thoughts, a ghastly symbol of everything she was afraid of. She yelled at Adora for a stupid argument and ran away before she saw her reaction, then kept poking a wind chime, high up in one of the palace towers, alone and regretful, until dinner.

Adora didn't say anything when she entered the room after that,

and to an outside observer, she would seem to have forgotten about the fight from earlier, if Catra couldn't see, as clear as ink on a page, the hurt and frustration in her eyes, well hidden behind the chatter of a half-finished day, with dessert and messy bedspread, waiting for her.

Ignoring was *so* tempting, it was the option she wanted to choose, even though she knew it was the wrong one, and she honestly would have done it if it were possible.

It wasn't, though, so she took a deep breath, gathered her courage, and showed her the collar.

Silently, she asked: “Is this what I am to you?”

Adora looked confused for a moment, then she huffed in exasperation, looking at the frayed leather lace she'd grabbed for a closer look.

“Are the guards being mean to you?”

It seemed like a random question, almost an evasion of the subject, if Catra hadn't noticed their behavior this past week. While Glimmer and Bow looked pleased to have her there, and the rest of the princesses, with some variation, swung between exasperation and appreciation at her presence—except for Scorpia. Scorpia, unfathomable as it was, looked as happy as Adora—the guards still looked at her crookedly, suspiciously, and annoyed, and Catra would have honestly misjudged them if they weren't.

“The guards?”

“Yeah, they tend to be... neurotic? – Adora said, a little uncertain with her own choice of words – It took some time for them to accept me too, in the first few months, they left horde crests in my room, to provoke me. I think they thought I was a spy or something.”

“Did the guards leave this? – Catra said, still confused by the idea – They think I…”

She shut her mouth tight before verbalizing, almost trapping her tongue between her teeth. What would Adora say if she asked her: "Do they think I'm your pet?". What would Catra do if the answer was "Yes"?

What would she do if her girlfriend thought they were right?

It wasn't fair to Adora, she knew that, but Catra couldn't help her thoughts, and putting them out like that, openly, hurt too much. That night, she got out of bed and went to sleep by the window, along with Melog.

It became a habit, then, for the next week. Reconstruction was underway, which kept them busy enough that they didn't see each other much during the day. As the logistics leader, Catra sent Adora on long missions as far as she could, and ignored most of her calls, claiming she was too busy. She knew she was pulling away, knew how damaging that could be, but wallowing in her own misery right now was almost irresistible.

"Don't you miss your mistress, kitten?" – one of the guards asked, at some point.

Catra hid to cry in the bathroom at night, because she was. The empty room looked bigger, darker, than it really was; Adora's scent had almost disappeared from the sheets, and the longing ached, burned, in her chest, like an infected wound left untreated.

The collar was still there, Catra had retrieved it from the trash, where Adora had dropped it, and clutched it to her chest. With trembling fingers, she unlocks the buckle and fastened it around her neck, before looking at herself in the mirror.

Red eyes, messy fur. She felt brittle, like misplaced shards of glass

that would scatter across the floor. Claws bared, she reached up to her neck and grabbed that band of frayed leather. She felt like she hated it more than she'd ever hated anything else in her life, but she couldn't muster the courage to cut it.

The promises, in that silver buckle, were so beautiful. Part of Catra wanted to accept them at once: Would it be so awful to actually be Adora's pet? Wasn't that what she'd always been, wasn't that what she'd always wanted to be? And yet...

It was just that? Even after all? Was that all she would ever mean?

So deep in her own thoughts, she nearly jumped when the bathroom door opened, and Adora walked in, rubbing her eyes. For a long time, they both just stared at each other, stunned by each other's presence, and Catra wasn't quick enough to regroup, to hide so much evidence of so many things that were wrong, at that moment, in herself.

"I got here early - Adora said then, but she could have said anything else, so far were her thoughts. Eyes fixed on her neck, she watched the collar tied like an alien object, questioning its existence and its role in the world - A group of civilians had already cleared part of the roads, supplies can be shipped now...”

Catra nodded then, uncertain what she should, wanted, to do. Was already on a leash, wasn't she? Shouldn't she go greet her mistress? Her skin ached from the lack of her touch, her mouth burned from the absence of her kisses, and yet she felt herself cringing, claws exposed, like a cornered animal, caught in the midst of fleeing and attacking.

Adora, to her credit, wasn't startled, even as she began to growl softly, backing away until her back touched the mirror. Catra imagined she was used to seeing her like this, unhinged, enraged —and God, how awful was that’s true? Catra had been a lifelong challenge, couldn't she give her even a moment of peace?!

Instead of striking back, or retreating, however, she walked slowly into the bathroom, taking short, careful steps and, very gently, reaching up to her neck and releasing the buckle.

She took a deep breath in response, as if the collar had been choking her until now, and only then did she realize it. Lungs full, a bit of reason came back to her, the more caught up in the moment she felt, and Catra realized how ridiculous her behavior had been in the last week. Embarrassed, she tried to apologize, searched for the right words that, in the right order, could make sense of this situation, but it all still felt too raw, too scary.

Catra couldn't even *look* at her now.

She was about to run away; she knew she was. The very natural response to everything she didn't understand, trained for a lifetime in the Horde, under Shadow Weaver's disgusted eyes, was very hard to ignore, if Adora hadn't suddenly turned the whole situation upside down.

Pushing her hair back from her neck, she put the collar.

Catra was surprised that there was no noise, that the earth hadn't shaken, because that gesture had the impact of an explosion, so disorienting that she almost recoiled, afraid of the shrapnel. Eyes locked with hers, Adora moved even closer to her, her hand gently stroking her fingers until she caught the leash, which Catra was crushing against her palm. Kneeling, she fastened it to the ring at her neck and offered her the strap.

Icy blues, very tender, very gentle, filled with an easy certainty that somehow calmed the storm of indecision in her heterochromia. Adora didn't look embarrassed, despite her flushed cheeks, and when Catra felt herself grip the leash strap, barely aware of her own actions, a smile filled her lips.

“Why?” - she asked, a word too small for that situation, turned around, inside out, a request for an explanation when *she* should

have been explaining herself.

Adora hummed in response, a sly, playful smile filling her lips.

"I'm not ashamed of being yours - she said, a few moments later. Her voice was calm, *meek* and yet totally balanced, an edge of solid steel in every word – Being yours is all I've ever wanted to be."

As if she hadn't cried enough already, her eyes filled with tears. A mixture of relief and gratitude balanced the cacophony of shame, confusion, and anger inside her, and Catra felt herself planting her feet more firmly on the floor, her shards rearranging themselves into something more solid, one that wouldn't crumble with the slightest gust of wind. Adora was silent, patient, for the entire time it took her to take a deep breath, calm her own heart, smooth her fur, and every second of it felt like a gift, a declaration.

She felt *so* grateful, for each and every one of them, when she felt she didn't deserve even the fraction of a single one.

Bringing her hands to her head, Catra stroked the gold of her hair, feeling something inside her chest liquefy, bubble, at the way Adora closed her eyes, her whole body relaxing against Catra's stomach where she pressed her face. At her navel, she felt her smile widen, her eyelashes flutter against her fur, her posture relax as if melting against her.

It wasn't what she was supposed to be doing right now, Catra knew they should talk about it, talk - you know, the thing they both never did right - but seeing Adora so comfortably wearing something that had brought her so much anguish over the past few weeks seemed to mend something inside her, as if she'd rubbed ointment into a burn and only now the pain had eased. Caressing her, as if she were indeed a pet—and not the sun and moon and stars, her oxygen and fresh water—Catra felt more sure of herself, a little more in control.

It was almost overwhelming, she'd never felt in control of anything, and having it given to her, now, for free, was so monumental that she could barely handle it, hesitantly holding it in her arms, like a baby, terrified by the idea of dropping it by accident.

"I missed you" - she said instead, because it was true, and she wanted to contribute something other than confusion and subjectivity to this situation.

“Me too - Adora replied, her words brushing kisses on her belly button - Don't send me away for so long, please.”

Please – she repeated, to herself, because it was her decision. *Please*, because Adora would go again if she said so, even if she didn't want to.

"I won't" - Catra promised, her voice breaking, as she squeezed her tighter into herself, slipping until she sat down in front of her.

Adora smiled, overjoyed, and Catra got a good look at her for the first time since she'd walked into the bathroom and into that ridiculous situation, to fix things she hadn't broken because it was who she was what she did. In her pajamas – she wondered why she hadn't heard her come in and change – with her legs and arms bared, she looked tired, as if she were minutes away from falling asleep, her hair untied from its bow falling around her face like grass in the autumn, and so beautiful it was almost blinding.

“Come on, let's sleep - Catra said, anxious to end the day and let rest clean up some of that mess - I'll give you tomorrow off.”

“Thanks - Adora replied, happily - Can I stay with you?”

"Of course" - Catra replied, with a smile, swallowing her guilt for having run away from that bed for so long.

She must have been more exhausted than she thought, though, because when she woke up, tucked between the quilts, she can barely remember putting herself there. Adora was still asleep, beside her, her face pressed firmly to her sternum and her arms stretched around her, fingers tangled in her hair. Legs intertwined, they were as close together as they could get, and yet Catra hated all the spots where she didn't feel the warm contact of her body.

Bending down, she kissed her forehead and breathed in her scent, a hint of steel and concrete from the day before that mingled, sweaty, with the natural scent of her skin, the scent of rain and thunder, wet grass and citrus, of her shampoo. It was still a delicious smell, a smell of home, hearth, of longing, of wanting.

Adora shifted in her embrace, half a dozen slurred words unraveling in her fur as she yawned and stretched out on the bed. When she lifted her head, Catra saw the collar, still around her neck, but – and she couldn't say why – didn't mention it.

“I remember you giving me time off - she said, then, with a lazy smile - Don't tell me it was a dream, it will break my heart.”

“It wasn't a dream - Catra laughed - I think I'll take the day too.”

She didn't think anyone would be bothered by this, they had both been working non-stop since the end of the war, they deserved a break.

“What do you want to do?”

It sounded unassuming, shitchat, but Catra felt there was a weight to the question. More than pillow talk, Adora was, she knew, asking her to decide, because she hadn't forgotten about the collar around her neck, and she seemed determined not to let Catra ignore it either.

Which was a problem, because Catra didn't know what it meant

now, and was too coward to ask.

“Let's take a shower, you stink...”

Adora pushed the pillow against her face and ran, laughing, to the bathroom. They showered together and washed each other's backs and hair, and no one mentioned the collar as they dressed, even though it practically burned in the space between them. The closer they were to leaving the room, the more anxious Catra felt, as if a defining moment stretched out in front of her, a Pandora's box she shouldn't open, but was dying to know what it contained.

If Adora left like this, the guards would see her. *Everyone* would see her, their hero, wearing an animal collar. What would they think of her?

Catra hated herself for hesitating to stop her, morbid curiosity as to whether she had the courage to freeze her muscles in front of the door. Unlike what she'd expected, what she should have, Adora didn't look disappointed or angry. She smiled and approached her, kissing her sweetly before saying:

“I'm starving, so I'll go ahead, okay?”

And, as if it were a normal day, Adora left the room, gently closing the door behind her, leaving Catra alone to deal with her open Pandora's box, all the nightmares contained within it suddenly unleashed in the empty room.

A second too late, she stepped forward to stop her, grabbed the latch, and felt herself collapse against it, kneeling on the floor, as if she had no bones. She laughed then, because what was that protest but an act to herself? A lie that no one but her, who knew the truth, would ever hear.

Catra couldn't muster the courage to leave after that. She sat by the window and looked out, closed her eyes and let the sound of the waterfall drown out all the voices in her head, each one trying

to scream louder than the other, none with good things to say to her.

Why did she let Adora leave the room?

Imagining her not having the courage to do this, backing off at the last second, felt scary at the moment, as if exposing an ugly truth between them, but now Catra felt like she would give anything to make that happen, because seeing Adora leave, with the collar around her neck, exposes something far worse about herself, something she didn't know how, or even if it was possible, to fix.

Why, Why, Why...

Hadn't Adora already done enough? – she wanted to grab herself by the neck and scream, to herself – after all, after everything Catra had done, did she really need to give more proof? When would it be enough? Why, in order to feel that she was worth something, did she need to show that Adora was worthless?

What would come next, would she hook that strap around her neck, and make her crawl behind her?

Why couldn't she be better? Just a little bit, just a fraction as good as Adora was...

I'm not ashamed of being yours - Adora had said.

Why, then, Catra's ashamed to be hers? Even when it was what she wanted most, what she needed more than blood in her veins or air in her lungs.

Sometime later, she had no idea how much, the door opened and closed, and she could hear Adora's footsteps approaching. Head buried in her arms, Catra could only cringe, terrified of what she would see in her eyes now.

“I brought you cake - Adora said, falling down next to her and taking a big mouthful of a slice, completely unfazed - But vanilla, I heard cats can't eat chocolate, bad luck for you.”

Throwing her head back, Catra laughed hard, all her breath escaping her like a beaver dam that breaks in the storm. It seemed to cleanse her from the inside out, as if she were spitting out the gall in her stomach to ease the pain, and even as tears streamed down her face, she felt joyful for the first time in *weeks*.

“I love you - she said, turning to Adora, who was smiling with her mouth full, her lips smeared with frosting and her eyes equally teary - I love you. I love you and I know it's not enough; I love you and I want to get better but it's hard and I'm so grateful that you always give me one more chance even if I don't deserve it.”

“Don't be so dramatic - Adora laughed, pulling her and pressing their faces together, as they did when they were children and Catra caressed her like kittens did - It's the two of us against the world, remember? Nothing bad will happen as long as we stick together.”

Catra nodded, melting against her and feeling as if she had honey in her veins instead of blood, her heart pulsing heat and sweetness throughout her body.

“Sorry I doubt you.”

“It’s okay - Adora replied, a self-deprecating smile, which definitely shouldn't be on her face, on her lips - It's not like I don't give you reasons to.”

“You didn't - she replied, and it was surprisingly easy to lift her hand and release the buckle from her neck, because now she felt whole and nothing could break her - But you're still an airhead, though...”

Adora frowned in confusion as Catra put the collar, jumping to the

floor and heading for the door, a smile plastered to her face and her step so light she felt like she was floating.

“You - she said, and sent her a smile over her shoulder, before opening the door and leaving the room - forgot your kitten's milk.”

End Notes

As always, my english ins't the better so, if something feels off somehow, let me know, I'll fix it if necessary.
Thanks for read ^ ^

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!